



△ Wallis Simpson, later the Duchess of Windsor, 1936

Duchess of Windsor's Cartier flamingo brooch

This Cartier flamingo was commissioned by the Duke of Windsor for Wallis Simpson, the woman for whom he gave up the British throne. It is one of the most famous of the numerous jewels that he bestowed on her.

The brilliant-cut, calibrated (uniformly sized) diamonds have a pavé setting in the platinum and yellow-gold base to create the glittering body and legs of the flamingo. The plumage of the wings and tail is composed of step-cut emeralds, rubies, and sapphires. The eye is a single sapphire cabochon (a polished rather than faceted stone) while the beak is formed from citrine and sapphire cabochons.

American socialite Wallis Simpson had already been twice divorced when she captured the attention of the heir to the British throne, Edward VIII, in 1934. The prince was determined to marry her at any cost, causing a crisis when the reigning monarch King George V



Duchess of Windsor's emerald and ruby 20th-anniversary Cartier brooch

died. Edward was now the head of the Church of England, which did not permit divorcées to remarry. Unable to bring himself to relinquish Simpson, Edward abdicated in 1936, and his younger brother George VI became king, granting Edward the title "Duke of Windsor".

Edward commissioned the flamingo brooch for his wife three years after their wedding. As materials, he supplied one of her necklaces and four of her bracelets to Cartier's director Jeanne Touissant in Paris. Touissant, together with her design partner, Peter Lemarchand, used the reclaimed gems to complete the flamingo jewel in 1940.

The Duke presented the brooch to his wife, now the Duchess of Windsor, for her birthday that year and it became one of her most treasured pieces. After her death it was owned by private collectors, and was exhibited by Cartier in 2013.



Duchess of Windsor's gem and diamond Cartier bracelet

Key dates

1934–2013

